repeatedly asserted that the Party is in command of the PLA and the military's first obligation is to defend the Party, only secondarily the country. As President of the country, he is also the supreme commander of the armed forces and frequently appears in military uniform while visiting PLA units or facilities. He is, of course, Chairman of the Central Military Commission, which is a Party organ overseeing the PLA.

Xi reorganized the earlier regional military commands into integrated theatre commands and functional commands, thus bringing about cohesive and coordinated operations. This has had the political consequence of diminishing the role of the land forces, which enjoyed a certain standing as legatee of the old communist revolutionary armies. The military reforms have greatly enhanced the efficacy of the PLA, which is also modernizing at a very rapid rate. While creating a much more powerful and modern military, Xi has also enhanced the Party's control over it.

Lastly, under Xi there has been a vigorous effort to impose Party orthodoxy over virtually every aspect of political, social and cultural activities. There is less tolerance for dissent and greater insistence on conformity to the Party's directives.

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The US–China trade war, the protectionist trends around the world, which have been reinforced by the pandemic, and the disruptions of regional and global supply chains in which China is the dominant player have enhanced the sense of vulnerability for the Chinese economy. Xi Jinping has signalled a turn towards a more self-reliant economic strategy based more on domestic demand and innovation than on investment and exports. This has been described as the 'dual circulation' strategy, encompassing both the external and domestic sectors but with the latter playing the dominant role. There is also a geopolitical dimension involved. In a speech at the Central Financial and Economic Work Conference on 10 April 2020, Xi Jinping called for 'building production chains and supply chains that are independently controllable', but went on to suggest that, at the same time, the country 'must tighten international production chains' dependence on